CBSE Class 10 History – Chapter 4

The Age of Industrialisation (Detailed Notes)

1. Before the Industrial Revolution

Before factories began to dot the landscape in England and Europe, there was large-scale industrial production for an international market. This phase is known as **Proto-Industrialisation**.

- **Proto-Industrialisation:** A period of commercial production before the rise of the modern factory system. Production was decentralized, controlled by merchants, and carried out by peasants within their family farms.
- **The Countryside Network:** Merchants from towns moved to the countryside, supplying money and raw materials to peasants and artisans. Close links developed between the town and countryside. Merchants were based in towns, but the work was done in rural areas.
- **Production Process:** A merchant clothier bought wool from a **Stapler** (who sorted wool according to its fiber), took it to the spinners, and then to **Fullers** (who gathered cloth by pleating) and dyers. The finishing was done in London before the product was sold internationally.

2. The Coming Up of the Factory

- The earliest factories in England came up by the **1730s**, but they multiplied rapidly in the late 18th century.
- **Cotton** was the first symbol of this new industrial era. Its production soared dramatically due to technological innovations.
- **Richard Arkwright** created the **cotton mill**. Prior to this, cloth production was scattered across the countryside. The mill brought all production processes (carding, twisting, spinning, and rolling) **under one roof and management**. This allowed for better quality control, careful supervision, and regulated labor.

3. The Pace of Industrial Change

- **Phase 1 (Dominant Sectors): Cotton and iron & steel** were the most dynamic industries. Cotton led the first phase of industrialization up to the 1840s, after which the expansion of railways in Britain and its colonies created a massive demand for iron and steel.
- **Phase 2 (Displacement):** The new advanced factories could not easily displace traditional industries. Even at the end of the 19th century, less than 20% of the total workforce was employed in technologically advanced industrial sectors.
- **Phase 3 (Small Innovations):** Traditional industries did not remain stagnant. They experienced slow changes brought about by small, ordinary technological innovations (like improved tools).
- **Phase 4 (Slow Adoption of Technology):** Technological advancements occurred slowly because the new machinery was expensive, required high maintenance costs, and often broke down. Industrialists were cautious about using them. *Example:* **James Watt** patented the improved **steam engine** in **1781**, but for years, he could not find buyers because industrialists still relied on manual labor.

4. Hand Labour and Steam Power

In Victorian Britain, industrialists preferred hand labor over steam power for several reasons:

- **Abundance of Labour:** There was no shortage of human labor. Poor peasants and vagrants moved to cities in large numbers, so wages were low. Industrialists had no incentive to introduce costly machines.

- **Seasonal Demand:** Many industries had seasonal labor requirements (e.g., gasworks, breweries, and bookbinders active in winter; ships being repaired in winter). Industrialists preferred hiring seasonal hand labor over year-round machine operations.
- **Range of Products:** Machines could only produce standardized, uniform goods for a mass market. However, market demand was often for intricate designs and specific shapes, which could only be made by human hands.

5. Life of the Workers

- **Job Insecurity:** Getting a job depended heavily on **personal connections or networks** of friendship and kin. If a worker did not know someone in a factory, they had to wait weeks, spending nights in night shelters or casual wards.
- **Seasonality of Work:** Periods of employment were followed by long months of joblessness.
- **The Spinning Jenny Conflict:** Invented by **James Hargreaves** in **1764**, this machine speeded up the spinning process by turning multiple spindles with a single wheel. Women workers, who survived on hand spinning, attacked the machines because they feared losing their livelihoods.
- **Infrastructure Boom:** After the 1840s, intensive building activity (railways, roads, tunnels, and sewers) in cities opened up new employment opportunities.

6. Industrialisation in the Colonies: The Indian Context

Before machine-age industries, India dominated the international textile market with its **finest varieties of finer cotton and silk goods**.

The Decline of Established Networks

- Before the British East India Company established political power, Indian merchants and bankers operated a highly lucrative network of export trade. By the 1750s, this network broke down as the East India Company secured monopolies.
- The Company eliminated existing traders and brokers to establish direct control over weavers through an appointed paid servant called a **Gomastha**.
- **Role of the Gomastha:** They supervised weavers, collected supplies, and inspected the quality of the cloth.
- **System of Advances (Loans):** Weavers were given loans to buy raw materials once an order was placed. However, those who took loans had to hand over their finished cloth exclusively to the Gomasthas, losing their freedom to sell to other buyers. This led to clashes, as Gomasthas often acted arrogantly and punished weavers for supply delays.

"Manchester Comes to India"

By the turn of the 19th century, weavers faced three major problems simultaneously:

1. **Collapse of Export Markets:** British cotton pieces began flooding the Indian market. As industrial groups in Britain pressurized their government to impose import duties on foreign cloth, Indian exports faced a steep decline.
2. **Glutted Local Markets:** Machine-made British goods from Manchester were cheaper and better finished, making it impossible for local handloom weavers to compete.
3. **Raw Cotton Shortage:** During the American Civil War (1860s), raw cotton supplies from the US to Britain were cut off. Britain turned to India, causing raw cotton prices to skyrocket. Indian weavers were starved of raw materials and could not afford to buy cotton at such high rates.

7. Factories Come Up in India

The mid-nineteenth century marked the beginning of modern factory production in India:

Year	Factory / Mill Type	Location
1854	First Cotton Mill (began production in 1856)	Bombay
1855	First Jute Mill (second one opened in 1862)	Bengal
1860s	Elgin Mill	Kanpur
1861	First Cotton Mill	Ahmedabad
1874	First Spinning and Weaving Mill	Madras

The Early Entrepreneurs

- **Dwarkanath Tagore:** Set up six joint-stock companies in Bengal during the 1830s and 1840s using wealth from China trade.
- **Dinshaw Petit and Jamsetjee Nusserwanjee Tata:** Built vast industrial empires in Bombay using wealth accumulated from trade with China and cotton exports.
- **Seth Hukumchand & Shiv Narayan Birla:** Established the first Indian jute mill in Calcutta.

Where Did the Workers Come From?

- Most workers migrated from surrounding agricultural districts (e.g., Ratnagiri district to Bombay cotton mills).
- **The Jobber:** Industrialists employed a trusted worker called a Jobber to recruit new workers. The Jobber became an influential figure who demanded money or favors in exchange for securing jobs.

8. Peculiarities of Industrial Growth

- **European Managing Agencies** controlled a large sector of Indian industries, focusing mostly on plantations (tea, coffee), mining, indigo, and jute for export rather than competing with British goods.
- **Yarn vs. Cloth:** Early Indian mills produced coarse cotton yarn rather than fabric. This yarn was either used by handloom weavers in India or exported to China.
- **Swadeshi Movement Impact:** During the Swadeshi Movement (1905), nationalists mobilized people to boycott foreign cloth. Indian industrialists shifted production from yarn to cloth to meet local demand.
- **The First World War Boost:** The war changed the industrial landscape entirely. British factories shifted to producing war supplies, stopping imports into India. Indian factories were called upon to supply war materials (jute bags, cloth for uniforms, tents, leather boots). This led to a massive boom in domestic industrial production.

9. Market for Goods (The Role of Advertisements)

- **Labels:** Manchester industrialists put labels like **"MADE IN MANCHESTER"** on cloth bundles to signify quality and build buyer confidence.
- **Images of Deities:** Advertisements prominently featured illustrations of Indian gods and goddesses (like Krishna or Saraswati) to give the imported products a familiar, divine sanction.
- **Calendars:** Manufacturers printed attractive calendars that were hung in tea shops, offices, and homes, keeping their brand visible all year long.
- **Nationalist Messages:** Indian manufacturers used advertisements as a vehicle for nationalist messaging, stating: *"If you care for the nation, then buy products made by Indians."*